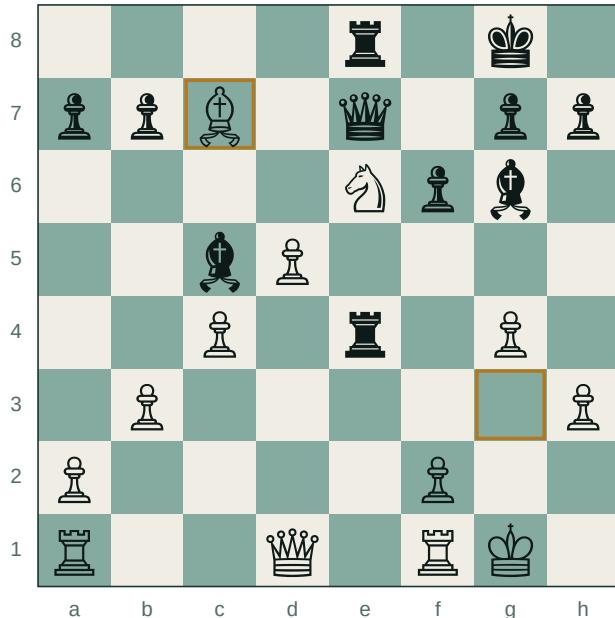


Capture the defender: Black, move 23

Capture the defender

Black to move



Previous move: 23.Bxc7. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

23...Rxe6 24. dxe6 Qxc7

23...Rxe6 The rook captures the knight on e6. Recorded reply: **24.dxe6**.

24...Qxc7 The queen captures the bishop on c7.

At the end, nominal material is White 26 / Black 25 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +1. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +1:** the balance goes from -2 to -1. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on g1. Absolute pin: pawn on f2.